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CUET UG

History

Early States & Economies

Theme 2 · Kings, Farmers and Towns (c. 600 BCE – 600 CE) · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

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Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

Sub-Topic Domain	Official NTA CUET UG Unit II Syllabus Scope	High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested
The 16 Mahajanapadas	Emergence of early states; monarchies vs ganas/sanghas; Magadhan ascendancy (Bimbisara to Nandas); Rajagriha and Pataliputra.	Evaluating geographic, mineral, and military factors underlying Magadha's supremacy; classifying oligarchies vs monarchies.
The Mauryan Empire	Chandragupta, Kautilya's Arthashastra, Megasthenes' Indica; Ashoka's Dhamma and epigraphy; 5 provincial capitals; military sub-committees.	Analyzing Mauryan administrative hierarchy; ordering Megasthenes' six military sub-committees; evaluating Ashokan Dhamma.
Notions of Kingship	Kushana divine kingship (Devaputra); Southern chiefdoms (Cholas, Cheras, Pandyas, Muventar); Gupta prashastis (Prayag Prashasti).	Interpreting monumental royal sculptures at Mat; analyzing royal legitimation strategies and court poetry eulogies.
Agrarian & Urban Society	Production strategies (iron ploughshare, transplantation, Sudarshana lake); rural stratification (Gahapati, Vellalar); Prabhavati Gupta's land grant.	Contrasting rural terminology in northern vs southern India; evaluating women's legal property rights under Vakatakas.
Numismatics & Epigraphy	Coinage evolution (punch-marked, Indo-Greek, Kushana, Gupta); James Prinsep's decipherment of Brahmi (1838) and Kharosthi; limits of epigraphy.	Tracing numismatic innovations; decipherment methodologies; evaluating methodological limitations of inscriptional evidence.

CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 2 questions in CUET UG focus heavily on terminology and epigraphic specifics:

1. **Megasthenes' Military Committees:** Megasthenes recorded **1 Committee** with **6 Sub-committees**: (1) Navy, (2) Transport and provisions, (3) Foot soldiers (Infantry), (4) Horses (Cavalry), (5) Chariots, (6) Elephants.
2. **Ashoka's Decipherment:** James Prinsep deciphered Brahmi in **1838**. Ashoka is titled **Devanampiya Piyadassi** ("Beloved of the Gods, of pleasant appearance"). His personal name **Ashoka** appears only in **Maski, Gujarra, Nittur, and Udegolam** edicts.
3. **Coinage Firsts:** First coins with names and portraits of rulers = **Indo-Greeks**; First gold coins = **Kushanas** (1st c. CE); Tribal coins = **Yaudheyas**; Most artistic and pure gold coins = **Guptas**.
4. **Prabhavati Gupta Exception:** Daughter of Chandragupta II, married into the Vakataka dynasty. Her copperplate grant of village **Danguna** demonstrates that royal women occasionally exercised independent property rights, violating strict Dharmashastric prohibitions.

The Emergence of the Sixteen Mahajanapadas

The sixth century BCE represents a major transformative watershed in early Indian history, characterized by rapid secondary urbanization, widespread adoption of iron metallurgy, the circulation of punch-marked coinage, and the consolidation of territorial states known as the **Mahajanapadas**.

Structural Features of the Mahajanapadas

Buddhist and Jaina canonical literatures (e.g., the **Anguttara Nikaya** and **Bhagavati Sutra**) enumerate sixteen prominent Mahajanapadas:

- **Two Political Polities:**
  - **Monarchies (Rajyas):** Governed by hereditary monarchs where Brahmanical political norms prevailed (e.g., Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, Avanti).
  - **Oligarchies (Ganas or Sanghas):** Republics governed collectively by aristocratic assemblies of clan leaders titled **Rajas** (e.g., the Vajjis of Vaishali and the Shakyas of Kapilavastu). Gautama Buddha and Vardhamana Mahavira both belonged to such republican ganas.
- **Fortified Capitals:** Every Mahajanapada maintained a heavily fortified capital city to defend against neighboring imperial expansions.
- **Emergence of Standing Armies:** Rulers abandoned seasonal tribal militias, establishing professional standing armies and regular state bureaucracies financed through systematic taxation (**bali** and **bhaga**).
- **Brahmanical Dharmasutras:** From the sixth century BCE onwards, Brahmanas began codifying normative Sanskrit legal manuals (**Dharmasutras**), establishing rules for rulers (who were ideally expected to be Kshatriyas) to collect taxes from peasants, traders, and artisans.

The Ascendancy of Magadha

Between the sixth and fourth centuries BCE, Magadha (in modern Bihar) emerged as the undisputed paramount imperial power among the sixteen states.

Strategic Factor	Geographical / Material Manifestation	Military & Political Implication
Agricultural Surplus	Alluvial floodplains of the Lower Ganga basin with abundant monsoon rainfall.	Generated colossal agricultural surpluses, sustaining massive standing armies and civic administration.
Iron Ore Deposits	Rich, accessible iron deposits located in nearby Chota Nagpur (Jharkhand).	Enabled the mass manufacture of iron weaponry, arrowheads, and heavy iron-tipped agricultural ploughs.
Military Elephant Herds	Dense forests of Jharkhand and Eastern India harbored vast herds of wild elephants.	Elephants were organized into a specialized military strike arm to crush opposing infantry and wooden gates.
Riverine Communications	Confluence of major waterways: Ganga, Son, and Gandak rivers.	Provided rapid, cheap military logistics and trade transport routes across northern India.
Natural Capital Defenses	Original capital **Rajagriha** (literally "House of the King") surrounded by five natural granite hills; later cap-	Virtually impregnable to siege warfare; allowed strategic command over eastern and central Gangetic trade corridors.

Strategic Factor	Geographical / Material Manifestation	Military & Political Implication
	ital **Pataliputra** commanded riverine highways.	

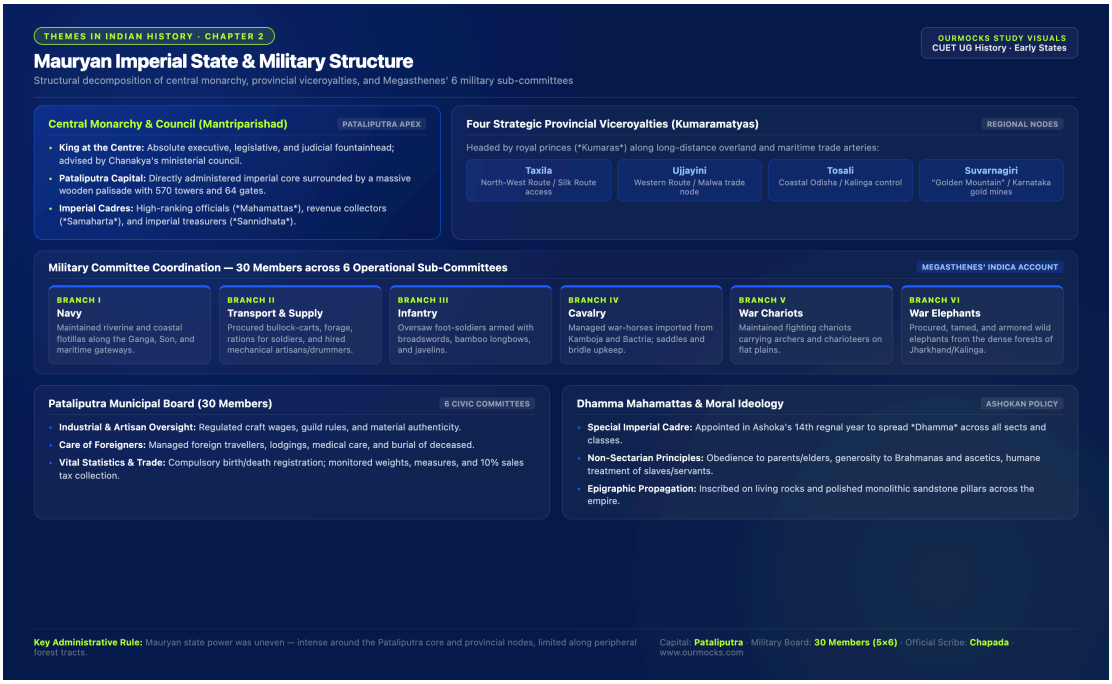


Figure 1: Mauryan Imperial Administrative Architecture, Provincial Capitals, and Military Hierarchy

The Mauryan Empire: Centralized Imperial Administration

Founded by Chandragupta Maurya in c. 321 BCE with the guidance of his minister Chanakya (Kautilya), the Mauryan Empire expanded across the subcontinent, extending to Afghanistan and Balochistan.

Core Historical Sources for Mauryan History

- **Megasthenes' Indica:** Eyewitness memoir of the Greek ambassador sent by Seleucus Nicator to Chandragupta's court at Pataliputra.
- **Kautilya's Arthashastra:** Treatise on statecraft, espionage, economic management, and imperial administration.
- **Inscriptions of Ashoka:** Epigraphic proclamations engraved on stone rocks and polished sandstone pillars across the empire.
- **Buddhist and Jaina Traditions:** Chronicle Ashoka's conversion to Buddhism and patronage of monastic orders.

Ashoka's Dhamma and Moral Governance

Following the catastrophic carnage of the Kalinga War (c. 261 BCE), Ashoka renounced aggressive territorial conquest (**Digvijaya**) in favor of moral conquest (**Dhammavijaya**).

- **Universal Ethical Principles of Dhamma:**
  - Respect toward parents, elders, teachers, and religious ascetics.
  - Generosity toward Brahmanas, Shramanas, and friends.
  - Humane treatment and compassionate conduct toward servants and enslaved laborers (**dasa-bhataka**).

- Religious tolerance: Abstaining from praising one's own religious sect while condemning others.

- **Dhamma Mahamattas:** A specialized ministerial administrative cadre created by Ashoka to travel throughout the empire and propagate Dhamma principles.

Provincial Administration & Communications

The vast empire was organized around five major geopolitical administrative centers:

1. **Pataliputra:** The imperial capital and administrative epicenter.
2. **Taxila (Takshashila):** Strategic northwestern frontier capital guarding overland Central Asian trade arteries.
3. **Ujjayini:** Central western crossroads controlling overland transit to western sea ports.
4. **Tosali:** Eastern provincial headquarters governing conquered Kalinga.
5. **Suvarnagiri:** The "Golden Mountain" in Karnataka, securing regional access to southern gold deposits.

Megasthenes' Military Committee System

Megasthenes explicitly documented that the imperial Mauryan military apparatus was coordinated by a single overarching military committee subdivided into **six specialized operational sub-committees**:

1. **First Sub-Committee:** Responsible for coordinating the **Navy**.
2. **Second Sub-Committee:** Managed **Transport, Provisions, and Logistics** (arranging bullock carts, carrying food for soldiers, fodder for animals, and recruiting artisans and medical attendants).
3. **Third Sub-Committee:** Supervised the **Foot Soldiers (Infantry)**.
4. **Fourth Sub-Committee:** Governed the **Horses (Cavalry)**.
5. **Fifth Sub-Committee:** Directed the **Chariots**.
6. **Sixth Sub-Committee:** Coordinated the **War Elephants**.



Figure 2: Decipherment of Early Scripts, Inscriptional Epigraphy, and Historiographical Methodology

New Notions of Kingship: Divine Monarchs and Prashastis

Following the disintegration of the Mauryan Empire, diverse new polities developed innovative ideological mechanisms to legitimize sovereign authority.

Southern Chiefdoms: The Tamilakam Triad

In peninsular South India, powerful chiefdoms emerged:

- **The Muventar:** Tamil Sangam poetry frequently celebrates the **Muventar** ("Three Crowned Chiefs"), referring to the dynasties of the **Cholas**, the **Cheras**, and the **Pandyas**.
- **Nature of Chiefdoms:** Chiefs relied on customary gift exchanges, redistributive tribute, and raids rather than permanent standing bureaucracies.

Kushana Divine Kingship

The Kushanas (c. first century BCE to third century CE), who ruled a vast empire from Central Asia to northwest India, cultivated an aura of celestial divinity:

- **Colossal Royal Statues:** Monumental, towering stone statues of Kushana kings were erected in dynastic shrines (**devakulas**) at **Mat near Mathura** (Uttar Pradesh) and in Surkh Kotal (Afghanistan).
- **The Divine Title "Devaputra":** Kushana monarchs adopted the prestigious title **Devaputra** ("Son of God"), directly emulating Chinese Han emperors who titled themselves "Sons of Heaven".

The Gupta Imperial Model & Prashastic Eulogies

The Gupta Empire (c. fourth to sixth centuries CE) depended heavily on subordinate feudatories titled **Samantas**:

- **The Concept of Prashasti:** Royal eulogistic inscriptions composed by court poets in ornate classical Sanskrit praising the ruler's military conquests and virtues.
- **The Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription):** Composed by court poet **Harishena** in praise of **Samudragupta**, describing him as an invincible warrior, an intellectual equal to the gods Indra, Varuna, and Yama, and a sovereign whose tender heart could be captured only by devotion.

Agrarian Transformation, Rural Stratification, and Land Grants

The expansion of early historical states was underpinned by systematic agricultural intensification.

Technological Innovations in Agriculture

1. **The Iron-Tipped Ploughshare:** Deployed extensively across the fertile alluvial river valleys of the Ganga and Kaveri from the sixth century BCE, bringing deep soils under cultivation.
2. **Transplantation of Paddy:** Farmers shifted from broadcasting seeds to growing seedlings in nurseries and transplanting them into flooded fields, drastically elevating crop yields while demanding arduous manual labor.
3. **Artificial Irrigation Facilities:** Construction of brick wells, community rainwater tanks, and monumental dams.

- **The Sudarshana Lake in Saurashtra (Gujarat):** A celebrated rock inscription at Junagadh records the multi-century history of the Sudarshana Lake reservoir:
  - Originally excavated under Chandragupta Maurya by provincial governor **Pushyagupta**.
  - Conduits added during Ashoka's reign by the Greek governor **Tushaspha**.

- Repaired in the 2nd century CE by Shaka ruler **Rudradaman I** using his own treasury without taxing the local populace.
- Repaired again in the 5th century CE under the Gupta emperor **Skandagupta**.

Rural Stratification and Social Hierarchy

Agrarian technology created profound socio-economic cleavages:

- **Northern India Hierarchy:**
  - **Gahapati:** The master, owner, or head of an agrarian household who controlled land, livestock, and agricultural property.
  - **Gramabhojaka / Gramani:** Hereditary village headman who collected royal revenue and exercised local judicial power.
- **Southern Tamilakam Hierarchy (Sangam Literature):**
  - **Vellalar:** Wealthy, large landowners.
  - **Uzhavar:** Peasant ploughmen.
  - **Adimai:** Landless agricultural laborers and bonded slaves.

Land Grants & The Prabhavati Gupta Enigma

From the early centuries of the Common Era, epigraphic records document **land grants** (**agrahara**—tax-free land donations made to Brahmanas or religious establishments), typically inscribed on copper plates:

- **Dharmashastric Legal Norm:** Classical legal treatises prohibited independent property ownership for women, dictating that women should be protected by fathers in childhood, husbands in youth, and sons in old age.
- **The Inscriptional Exception of Prabhavati Gupta:** Prabhavati Gupta was the daughter of the Gupta emperor Chandragupta II and queen of the Vakataka ruler Rudrasena II. Following her husband's death, she served as regent. Her copperplate grant donating the village of **Danguna** to an Acharya proves that royal women could possess and alienate property, transcending normative legal codes.

Urban Economy, Guilds, and Numismatic Evolution

Urban centers thrived along major trans-continental overland and maritime commercial networks.

Urban Nodes & Commercial Guilds (Shrenis)

Cities served specialized functions: Pataliputra (riverine trade), Ujjayini (inland crossroads), Puhar (coastal maritime port), and Mathura (cultural, political, and commercial center).

- **The Role of Shrenis:** Merchants and artisans were organized into corporate associations known as **Shrenis** (guilds), which procured raw materials, trained apprentices, standardized quality, and financed religious endowments.
- **The Mandasor Silk Weavers Inscription:** A fifth-century CE Sanskrit inscription from Mandasor (ancient Dashapura, Madhya Pradesh) records that a guild of silk weavers migrated from **Lata** (Gujarat) to Dashapura, attracted by the enlightened rule of the local king, and jointly financed the construction of a magnificent Sun temple.

The Evolutionary Trajectory of Coinage

Coinage Classification	Issuing Authority	Numismatic & Metallurgical Characteristics
Punch-Marked Coins	Early States, Kings, and Merchant Guilds (c. 6th c. BCE)	Silver and copper coins stamped with symbolic punches (sun, tree, bull, hill). Earliest metallic currency in South Asia.
Indo-Greek Coins	Hellenistic Indo-Greek Rulers (c. 2nd c. BCE)	First coins in Indian history to bear the **names, titles, and royal portraits** of kings.
Kushana Gold Coins	Kushana Dynasty (c. 1st c. CE)	First gold coins minted in India. High metallurgical purity; identical in weight standards to contemporary Roman and Parthian coins.
Yaudheya Tribal Coins	Yaudheya Republican Tribe (c. 1st c. CE)	Copper coins issued by autonomous warrior tribal republics of Punjab and Haryana, proving vibrant tribal commercial engagement.
Gupta Gold Coins	Gupta Dynasty (c. 4th–6th c. CE)	Celebrated for exquisite artistic beauty, calligraphic Sanskrit legends, and purity. Portrayed emperors playing the veena, hunting lions, or performing Ashvamedha.

Decipherment of Early Scripts & Limits of Inscriptional Evidence

Inscriptions constitute primary epigraphic records, but extracting historical truth requires rigorous hermeneutical caution.

James Prinsep and the Epigraphic Breakthrough

For centuries, early Indian inscriptions remained an unreadable enigma.

- **The 1838 Breakthrough:** James Prinsep, an officer in the Calcutta Mint of the East India Company, successfully deciphered the ancient **Ashokan Brahmi** script in 1838.
- **Decipherment Method:** Prinsep compared recurring Sanskrit and Prakrit votive inscriptions on the Sanchi stupas, identifying the word **danam** ("gift") and correlating character shapes with early Devanagari.
- **Kharosthi Decipherment:** Deciphered through bilingual Indo-Greek coins, where royal Greek names (e.g., **Menander**) were matched letter-by-letter with corresponding Kharosthi characters.

Methodological Limitations of Epigraphy

Historians confront four critical structural constraints when using inscriptional evidence:

1. **Technical Limitations:** Letters are often very faintly engraved, eroded by weather, or fractured, creating irreparable textual gaps.
2. **Linguistic & Translation Ambiguity:** Determining exact meanings of ancient idioms and technical administrative titles is exceptionally difficult.
3. **Patronage Bias:** Inscriptions record the perspective of wealthy patrons, royal courts, and ruling elites; they completely ignore the daily experiences of peasants, pastoralists, women, and marginalized laborers.
4. **Selective Survival:** Thousands of inscriptions engraved on perishable palm leaves and cloth decayed, leaving a partial and skewed historical archive.

Inscriptional Geography: Corpus and Classifications of Ashokan Edicts

The epigraphic corpus of Ashoka constitutes the earliest dated textual archive in Indian history, incised upon natural rock faces and polished monolithic sandstone pillars:

Edict Classification	Script & Language	Prominent Inscriptional Sites & Imperial Significance
Major Rock Edicts (14)	Prakrit in Brahmi; Aramaic & Kharosthi in Northwest	Engraved on frontier peripheral boundaries: Girnar (Gujarat), Kalsi (Uttarakhand), Sopara (Maharashtra), Dhauli & Jaugada (Odisha), Yerragudi (Andhra Pradesh), Shahbazgarhi & Mansehra (Pakistan).
Pillar Edicts (7)	Prakrit in Brahmi; carved on polished Chunar sandstone	Erected in the Gangetic heartlands: Topra and Meerut (transported to Delhi by Firoz Shah Tughlaq), Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, Rampurva (Bihar), and Sarnath.
Minor Rock & Pillar Edicts	Prakrit in Brahmi	Personal declarations of Buddhist faith: Bhabru (Rajasthan), Maski (Karnataka), Sasaram (Bihar), Rummindei (Lumbini, Nepal - recording tax exemption on Buddha's birthplace).
Kandahar Bilingual Edict	Greek and Aramaic	Incised at Shar-i-Kuna (Kandahar, southern Afghanistan) for Greek and Aramaic-speaking border subjects, demonstrating cosmopolitan imperial outreach.

Administrative Bureaucracy: The Arthashastra Governance Blueprint

Kautilya's **Arthashastra** conceptualizes the state through the **Saptanga** (seven-limb) theory: **Swami** (king), **Amatya** (ministers), **Janapada** (territory and population), **Durga** (fortified capital), **Kosha** (treasury), **Danda** (military force), and **Mitra** (allies).

Specialized Departmental Superintendents (Adhyakshas)

The day-to-day imperial economy was administered by executive superintendents:

- **Samaharta:** The Chief Collector-General of Revenue, supervising taxation from agriculture, mines, forests, and customs.
- **Sannidhata:** The Chief Treasurer, managing the state treasury, royal storehouses, and state granaries.
- **Sitadhyaksha:** Superintendent of Agriculture, supervising direct farming operations on state-owned crown lands (**sita**).
- **Pautavadhyaksha:** Superintendent of Standard Weights and Measures, enforcing accurate commercial balances.
- **Navadhyaksha:** Superintendent of Shipping, regulating riverine ferries, customs ports, and maritime trade traffic.

- **Lavanadhyaksha:** Superintendent of the royal state monopoly over salt manufacturing.
- **Gudhapurushas (Espionage Network):** A pervasive secret intelligence service categorized into **Sansthas** (stationary spies operating disguised as merchants, ascetics, or fortune-tellers) and **Sancharas** (mobile wandering operatives).

Ancient Trade Corridors, Votive Records, and Roman Commerce

Long-distance trade linked the Indian subcontinent with Mediterranean Europe and Central Asia:

Trans-Continental Trade Networks & The Roman Influx

During the early centuries of the Common Era, trade between India and the Roman Empire reached extraordinary heights:

- **The Periplus of the Erythraean Sea:** An anonymous Greco-Roman maritime manual (c. 1st c. CE) detailing coastal ports: Barygaza (Bharuch), Muziris (Kodungallur, Kerala), and Arikamedu (near Puducherry).
- **Trade Commodities:** India exported black pepper (celebrated in Latin literature as **Yavanapriya**—"dear to the Westerners"), fine Gangetic muslins, malabathrum, ivory, beryl, and pearls.
- **The Roman Coin Hoards:** In exchange, Rome exported massive quantities of silver and gold bullion (**denarii** and **aurei**). Giant hoards of Roman coins excavated across peninsular India (Coimbatore, Madurai) testify to a favorable commercial balance of trade that caused historian Pliny the Elder to lament the continuous drain of Roman gold to India.

Votive Inscriptions & Guild Endowments

Thousands of short **votive inscriptions** engraved on stupa railings and cave monasteries document the social base of early urban patronage:

- **Broad Socio-Economic Spectrum:** Donors identified themselves by profession: **vanij** (petty merchants), **sarthavaha** (caravan merchant leaders), **tantuvaya** (weavers), **kumbhakara** (potters), **suvarnakara** (goldsmiths), **karmakara** (blacksmiths), and **gahapatis**.
- **Guild Banking (Akshayanivi):** Inscriptions record that royal donors and affluent citizens deposited permanent money endowments with trade guilds (**shrenis**), with explicit contractual stipulations that the monthly interest earned must fund free meals for Buddhist monks or lamps in temples in perpetuity.

Regional Epigraphic Traditions: Satavahanas and the Language Transition

The post-Mauryan centuries witnessed major linguistic transitions in royal epigraphy across regional kingdoms:

1. The Linguistic Shift from Prakrit to Sanskrit

- **The Early Dominance of Prakrit:** All Ashokan edicts, early stupa votive records, and early Satavahana inscriptions were composed in **Prakrit**, the vernacular language of ordinary people.
- **The Sanskrit Breakthrough:** In the second century CE, the Western Kshatrapa ruler **Rudradaman I** commissioned the celebrated **Junagadh rock inscription** (c. 150 CE) in ornate classical **Sanskrit** prose, marking the triumphant imperial adoption of Sanskrit for public political discourse.

- **Gupta Sanskrit Hegemony:** By the Gupta era, Sanskrit had become the universal prestige language of royal courts, land grants, and imperial prashastis across the subcontinent.

2. Satavahana Inscriptions and Metronymic Royalty

In the Deccan, the Satavahana dynasty (c. 1st c. BCE to 2nd c. CE) left rich inscriptional archives in Buddhist rock-cut chaityas and caves at Nasik, Karle, and Kanheri:

- **The Metronymic Practice:** Satavahana kings derived names from their mothers—e.g., **Gautamiputra Satakarni** (son of Gautami) and **Vashishtiputra Pulumayi** (son of Vashishti).
- **Patrilineal Dynastic Reality:** While royal titles reflected reverence for maternal lineages, political succession to the royal throne was strictly **patrilineal** (from father to son).
- **Immunity in Land Grants:** Satavahana copperplate charters granted tax exemptions (**pariharas**) and forbade royal soldiers and revenue inspectors from entering gifted monastic villages, establishing the institutional foundation of early medieval agrarian feudalism.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Hierarchical Knowledge Architecture: Early States, Mauryan Administration, Agrarian Society, and Epigraphy

CUET HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & EPISTEMIC ASSOCIATIONS

- **16 Mahajanapadas:** 6th century BCE; monarchies vs ganas/sanghas (Vajjis, Shakyas).
- **Magadha Supremacy:** Iron mines (Jharkhand), fertile alluvium, military elephants, river transport, impregnable Rajagriha & Pataliputra.
- **Mauryan Five Capitals:** Pataliputra (capital), Taxila (NW trade), Ujjayini (central trade), Tosali (Kalinga), Suvarnagiri (gold).
- **Megasthenes 6 Military Sub-Committees:** 1. Navy, 2. Transport/Logistics, 3. Infantry, 4. Cavalry, 5. Chariots, 6. Elephants.
- **Ashoka Inscriptions:** Brahmi and Kharosthi deciphered by James Prinsep (1838); personal name Ashoka in Maski, Gujarra, Nittur, Udegolam.
- **Numismatic Firsts:** Names and portraits = Indo-Greeks; First gold coins = Kushanas; Tribal copper = Yaudheyas; Purest artistic gold = Guptas.
- **Rural Terminology:** South: Vellalar (large owners), Uzhavar (ploughmen), Adimai (slaves); North: Gahapati (master/owner), Gramabhojaka (headman).
- **Sudarshana Lake:** Pushyagupta (Chandragupta) → Tushaspha (Ashoka) → Rudradaman (Shaka) → Skandagupta (Gupta).
- **Prabhavati Gupta:** Daughter of Chandragupta II, Vakataka queen; granted village Danguna; exception to Dharmashastric property bans on women.

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — EARLY STATES & ECONOMIES

1. Mahajanapadas & Magadha:

- 16 states, 6th c. BCE. Magadha emerged dominant: iron, elephants, alluvium, Rajagriha hills.

2. Mauryan Empire (c. 321–185 BCE):

- Sources: Megasthenes' Indica, Kautilya's Arthashastra, Ashokan Edicts.
- 5 Centers: Pataliputra, Taxila, Ujjayini, Tosali, Suvarnagiri.
- Military: 1 Committee with 6 Sub-committees (Navy, Transport, Infantry, Cavalry, Chariots, Elephants).

3. Kingship Ideologies:

- Kushanas: Devaputra ("Son of God"), colossal statues at Mat.
- Guptas: Samantas; Prayag Prashasti by Harishena praising Samudragupta.

4. Economy & Agrarian Structure:

- Iron ploughshare, paddy transplantation, Sudarshana lake.
- Land grants: Agrahara (to Brahmanas); Prabhavati Gupta's Danguna grant.

5. Coins & Inscriptions:

- Punch-marked (earliest) → Indo-Greek (portraits) → Kushana (gold) → Gupta (artistic gold).
- Decipherment: James Prinsep (1838). Limitations: faint letters, missing portions, elite bias.

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS — EARLY STATES & ECONOMIES

- **Trap 1: Personal Name of Ashoka:** Most edicts call him **Devanampiya Piyadassi**. The name **Ashoka** appears only in **Maski, Gujarra, Nittur, and Udegolam**!
- **Trap 2: First Gold Coins in India:** The **Kushanas** issued the first gold coins in the 1st century CE, NOT the Guptas! (Guptas issued the most numerous and artistic gold coins).
- **Trap 3: Megasthenes' Military Committees:** There was **ONE** committee with **SIX** sub-committees, NOT six separate committees!
- **Trap 4: Sudarshana Lake Repairer:** Rudradaman I repaired it in the 2nd century CE without taxing the people; it was originally built under Chandragupta Maurya.
- **Trap 5: Gahapati vs Vellalar: Gahapati** is the northern term for household master/ landowner; **Vellalar** is the southern Tamil term for large landowners.
- **Trap 6: Prabhavati Gupta's Dynasty:** She was born a **Gupta** princess and married into the **Vakataka** dynasty of the Deccan.
- **Trap 7: Mandasor Inscription Guild:** The guild was composed of **Silk Weavers** who migrated from Lata (Gujarat) to Dashapura (MP).

Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

Part 1: High-Yield Conceptual Foundations & Mauryan Administration (Q1 to Q5)

Q1. Which scholar of the East India Company Mint and Asiatic Society of Bengal successfully deciphered the ancient Ashokan Brahmi and Kharosthi scripts in 1838?

(A) Alexander Cunningham (B) James Prinsep
(C) John Marshall (D) Mortimer Wheeler

Sol. Q1. James Prinsep and Brahmi Decipherment:

- **James Prinsep**, an officer in the Calcutta Mint of the East India Company, deciphered Ashokan Brahmi in 1838.
- He identified the recurring word **danam** on Sanchi stupa votive records and matched letter shapes with Devanagari.

Therefore, the scholar was **James Prinsep** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q2. In which of the following Minor Rock Edicts is the historical personal name 'Ashoka' explicitly inscribed alongside his celebrated royal titles?

(A) Maski Minor Rock Edict (B) Rummindei Pillar Edict
(C) Bhabru Rock Edict (D) Kalinga Rock Edict XIII

Sol. Q2. Personal Name of Ashoka:

- In most inscriptions, Ashoka is referred to only as **Devanampiya** ("Beloved of the Gods") and **Piyadassi** ("of pleasant appearance").
- His personal name **Ashoka** appears in only four inscriptions: **Maski**, **Gujarra**, **Nittur**, and **Udegolam**.

Therefore, the correct edict is **Maski Minor Rock Edict** (Option A). **Answer: (A)**

Q3. Which ruling dynasty of the early centuries of the Common Era was the first in Indian history to issue wide-scale gold coinage, matching the weight standards of contemporary Roman and Parthian coins?

(A) The Mauryan Dynasty (B) The Gupta Dynasty
(C) The Kushana Dynasty (D) The Indo-Greek Rulers

Sol. Q3. First Gold Coinage in India:

- The **Kushanas** were the first dynasty in the Indian subcontinent to mint gold coins in the 1st century CE.
- These coins were virtually identical in weight to coins issued by Roman emperors and Parthian rulers of Iran.

Therefore, the dynasty was the **Kushana Dynasty** (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Q4. According to the eyewitness accounts of Megasthenes recorded in his work Indica, how was the Mauryan imperial military apparatus organized at Pataliputra?

(A) A single unified committee coordinated by twenty provincial generals (B) One military committee assisted by six specialized sub-committees
(C) Six independent military boards reporting directly to tribal chiefs (D) Four specialized defense councils corresponding to the four varnas

Sol. Q4. Megasthenes' Military Committee System:

- Megasthenes explicitly recorded **one military committee** assisted by **six specialized sub-committees**: (1) Navy, (2) Transport and provisions, (3) Infantry, (4) Cavalry, (5) Chariots, and (6) Elephants.

Therefore, Option B accurately describes the structure. **Answer: (B)**

Q5. The celebrated Prayag Prashasti (Allahabad Pillar Inscription), detailing the military conquests and divine virtues of Samudragupta, was composed in ornate classical Sanskrit by his court poet named:

(A) Banabhatta (B) Kalidasa
(C) Harishena (D) Ravikirti

Sol. Q5. Harishena and the Prayag Prashasti:

- **Harishena**, the court poet (**Mahadandanayaka**) of Samudragupta, composed the famous **Prayag Prashasti** in Sanskrit, engraved on the Ashokan pillar at Allahabad.
- (Banabhatta was Harsha's poet; Ravikirti composed the Aihole inscription of Pulakeshin II).

Therefore, the poet was **Harishena** (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Part 2: Applied Agrarian Systems & Regional Polities (Q6 to Q10)

Q6. The ancient rock-cut Sudarshana Lake in the Junagadh region of Gujarat, originally excavated under the Mauryas, was extensively repaired and restored without levying any tax on local subjects in the second century CE by which ruler?

(A) Gupta Emperor Chandragupta II
(B) Shaka Ruler Rudradaman I
(C) Satavahana King Gautamiputra Satakarni
(D) Kushana Emperor Kanishka I

Sol. Q6. Sudarshana Lake and Rudradaman:

- The Junagadh rock inscription of the Shaka ruler **Rudradaman I** (c. 150 CE) records that a violent storm breached the dam of Sudarshana Lake.
- Rudradaman reconstructed the dam using his own private treasury without imposing any special emergency tax (**kara**) on the citizens of Saurashtra.

Therefore, the ruler was **Shaka Ruler Rudradaman I** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q7. Prabhavati Gupta, who exceptionally granted the village of Danguna along with land privileges despite general Dharmashastric restrictions on women owning property, was the daughter of which prominent imperial ruler?

(A) Samudragupta
(B) Chandragupta I
(C) Kumaragupta I
(D) Chandragupta II

Sol. Q7. Prabhavati Gupta's Lineage:

- Prabhavati Gupta was the daughter of the Gupta emperor **Chandragupta II** (Chandragupta Vikramaditya).
- She married into the prominent **Vakataka** dynasty of the Deccan and acted as regent, issuing land grants.

Therefore, her father was **Chandragupta II** (Option D). **Answer: (D)**

Q8. What was the term used in early historical northern India for the master, owner, or head of an agrarian household who exercised direct control over land, livestock, and family wealth?

(A) Gahapati
(B) Gramabhojaka
(C) Vellalar
(D) Adimai

Sol. Q8. The Term Gahapati:

- In Pali and Sanskrit texts, a **Gahapati** was the head of a household who exercised control over the women, children, slaves, and property (land, cattle, gold) belonging to the household.
- He was also an owner and master of agrarian farmland.

Therefore, the term was **Gahapati** (Option A). **Answer: (A)**

Q9. Match the early historical administrative capital in Column I with its strategic geographical location or economic role in Column II:

Column I (Capital)	Column II (Strategic Role)
A. Taxila	1. Capital situated on central western overland trade routes
B. Ujjayini	2. Northwestern frontier gateway on trans-Asian routes
C. Suvarnagiri	3. Riverine imperial capital of Magadha on the Ganga
D. Pataliputra	4. Southern center controlling access to Karnataka gold mines

Choose the correct matching code:

(A) A-1, B-2, C-4, D-3
(B) A-2, B-4, C-1, D-3
(C) A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3
(D) A-3, B-1, C-2, D-4

Sol. Q9. Provincial Capitals Matching:

- Taxila: Northwestern gateway on trans-Asian trade routes (A-2).
- Ujjayini: Center situated on western overland trade routes (B-1).
- Suvarnagiri: "Golden Mountain" accessing Karnataka gold mines (C-4).
- Pataliputra: Riverine imperial capital on the Ganga (D-3).

Therefore, the correct matching code is A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3 (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Q10. Tamil Sangam literature refers to the term 'Muventar' to celebrate which three prominent ruling dynasties of the ancient Tamilakam region?

(A) The Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandyas
(B) The Satavahanas, the Vakatakas, and the Kadambas
(C) The Pallavas, the Chalukyas, and the Rashtrakutas
(D) The Hoysalas, the Kakatiyas, and the Yadavas

Sol. Q10. The Muventar in Sangam Literature:

- The Tamil word **Muventar** means "Three Chiefs".
- It was used to designate the heads of the three celebrated ruling dynasties of Tamilakam: the **Cholas**, the **Cheras**, and the **Pandyas**.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

Part 3: Advanced Evaluative & Epigraphic Scenarios (Q11 to Q15)

Q11. What was the title of the special ministerial cadre created by Emperor Ashoka to travel throughout the Mauryan Empire and propagate the universal moral tenets of Dhamma?

(A) Rajukas (B) Samahartas
(C) Dhamma Mahamattas (D) Yuktas

Sol. Q11. Dhamma Mahamattas:

- Ashoka created a special administrative cadre of officials known as **Dhamma Mahamattas**.
- Their specific mandate was to travel across the empire to spread the message of Dhamma and ensure compassionate treatment of subjects.

Therefore, the cadre was titled **Dhamma Mahamattas** (Option C). **Answer: (C)**

Q12. Punch-marked coins, the earliest metallic currency of the Indian subcontinent (c. sixth century BCE onwards), were manufactured primarily from which metals?

(A) Lead and nickel (B) Silver and copper
(C) Gold and platinum (D) Pure iron and bronze

Sol. Q12. Punch-Marked Coinage Metallurgy:

- **Punch-marked coins** were stamped pieces of metal made predominantly of **silver** and **copper**.
- They bore specific symbols (hills, trees, animals) punched onto the flan using separate punches.

Therefore, they were minted from **Silver and copper** (Option B). **Answer: (B)**

Q13. A fifth-century CE Sanskrit inscription from Mandasor (ancient Dashapura in Madhya Pradesh) provides rare and fascinating details about the corporate history, social mobility, and religious patronage of a guild of:

(A) Ivory carvers migrating from Vidisha (B) Armorers and chariot makers from Taxila
(C) Horse traders migrating from the Makran coast (D) Silk weavers migrating from the Lata region of Gujarat

Sol. Q13. Mandasor Silk Weavers Guild:

- The famous **Mandasor stone inscription** records the migration of a guild (**shreni**) of **silk weavers** from Lata (Gujarat) to Dashapura (Madhya Pradesh).
- It describes how they were fascinated by the local ruler and jointly funded the construction of a temple dedicated to the Sun god (**Surya**).

Therefore, Option D accurately identifies the guild. **Answer: (D)**

Q14. Why do modern historians emphasize that inscriptional evidence cannot be accepted uncritically as a complete and objective mirror of ancient society?

(A) Inscriptions predominantly express the perspectives and political achievements of royal patrons and social elites, leaving routine rural life unrecorded (B) Ancient rulers were legally barred from inscribing political victories on stone
(C) Brahmanas exclusively destroyed all secular stone inscriptions during the early medieval period (D) Most ancient inscriptions were written in cipher languages that lacked phonetic grammar

Sol. Q14. Historiographical Limitations of Inscriptions:

- Epigraphy suffers from inherent perspective bias: inscriptions record what those who commissioned them (kings, wealthy patrons, religious leaders) wished to state.
- They remain conspicuously silent on the daily trials, poverty, and joys of commoners, peasants, agricultural slaves, and women.

Therefore, Option A correctly states this critical limitation. **Answer: (A)**

Q15. Which of the following dynasties was the first in Indian history to issue coins bearing the names and realistic portraits of ruling monarchs?

(A) The Mauryas (B) The Kushanas
(C) The Guptas (D) The Indo-Greeks

Sol. Q15. Indo-Greek Numismatic Innovation:

- The **Indo-Greeks**, who established kingdoms in the northwestern parts of the subcontinent in the second century BCE, were the very first to mint coins carrying the **names, titles, and royal portraits** of kings.

Therefore, the first dynasty was the **Indo-Greeks** (Option D). **Answer: (D)**